Worksheet W4 · W-Seminar "Time"

Research question and thesis

From a topic to a question you can answer – and to the claim you will put to the test.

1 A question and its answer

Research question open, focused what you investigate → sources + your own data → **Thesis statement** a claim your expected answer

revise if needed

spark question (W2–W3) → research question (W4 · fixed by the end of 12/1) → working thesis (W4–W5) → testable claim (W6–W7 · for data: your hypothesis) → thesis statement (the paper · backed by your results)

Your question grows. From now on every worksheet has a box **My question – version n**: improve your last version, note what changed and why. Keep the old versions – they show how your research developed.

In your own words: how do question and thesis work together?

The question says what I want to find out; the thesis is my expected answer – a claim that sources and my own data can confirm or prove wrong. If the data disagree, I revise the thesis.

2 Six markers of a good research question

Focused Who or what exactly? Where, when?
Open no one-search answer, no plain yes/no, no built-in answer
Researchable Are there sources to build on?
Open question words: *How … / To what extent … / In what ways … / Why …*

Testable Can I collect my own data?
Feasible 10–15 pages? Time, access, ethics?
Relevant So what? And is it about time?

3 Spot the problem

Which marker does each question miss most? Then improve one of them.

question	missing marker
a) What is the Mayan calendar?	*Open (one search answers it)*
b) How does time affect people?	*Focused (who? which effect?)*
c) Will humans ever travel back in time?	*Testable (no own data possible)*
d) How did all English novels of the 20th century deal with time?	*Feasible (far too much material)*

My improved version of *b)* :

How do Year 12 students' estimates of a 10-minute break differ when they spend it on their phones or talking to friends?

4 From question to thesis

A thesis statement …

- **answers** the question directly
- is **arguable** – not a fact, not a taste
- is **specific** – group, material, direction
- is **testable** – a result could prove it wrong
- is **short** – one or two sentences

Question: To what extent does checking a phone during homework change how long students think they worked?

Your working thesis:

Students who check their phones during homework think they worked longer than they actually did – their estimate is further off than that of students without a phone.

5 Work phase: read to orient

10 min · aim for 1–3 options by the end of today

My spark: _____

Keywords (English): _____

Names (researchers, authors, works): _____

A debate – where do people disagree? _____

strategies + builder

6 Question storm

5 min · at least 10 questions · no judging · then mark O (open) / C (closed) and star your best three

7 My question – version 1

three candidates

spark → question → working thesis → testable claim → thesis

	research question	working thesis	my own data – from whom?
1			
2			
3			

8 Draw the line – for your strongest option

In material · people · time span · aspect · method

Out – on purpose

This paper focuses on _____

It does not _____

9 Partner check

- ☐ So what – who would want to know?
- ☐ What exactly will you collect, from whom?
- ☐ Which result would prove your thesis wrong?
- ☐ Too big, too small – or right for 10–15 pages?

My partner's tip · my next step